The Chapter of Barzawayh the Physician[11]

Barzawayh, the chief physician of Persia, who copied out and translated this 3.1
book of Indian provenance, related: My father belonged to the military, and my mother to a family of Zoroastrian clergy. A mark of God's great favor toward me was that I was my parents' favorite child and that when I reached the age of seven, they sent me to study medicine.[12] When I reached the age of ten and had become better acquainted with medicine and its merits, I thanked my parents for their decision and was eager to study it further. I applied myself and acquired enough confidence to trust myself attending to the sick, and was about to begin my practice, but then I stopped to consider. I asked myself to choose among the four goals for which men strive. Which of these four, I asked, should someone of my profession seek? Which, when pursued, is most likely to give satisfaction: wealth, pleasure, fame, or reward in the hereafter? Medicine, I found, was praised by all who possess intelligence and was censured by no religious community. I read in medical texts that the best physician was the one who practiced his craft solely for heavenly reward, so I decided to seek heavenly reward through medical practice and demand no other payment. I didn't want to be like the unfortunate merchant who, for a worthless bead, traded a ruby that would have made his fortune forever. I also read in the medical texts that the physician who through his craft seeks reward in the hereafter is not precluded from achieving success in this world. He is like a farmer who plows and cultivates his land to grow crops, rather than grass; yet inevitably the land produces various kinds of grass, too.

I therefore set out to treat the sick with my hopes fixed on reward in 3.2
the hereafter. I never abandoned a patient whom I hoped to cure or, if that proved impossible, whose pain and suffering I hoped to alleviate, without

treating him to the best of my ability. If possible, I attended to him personally; if I couldn't, I diagnosed, instructed, and dispensed medicine. Hoping for reward in the next world, I demanded no fee or remuneration from any patient. I envied none of my colleagues who equaled me in knowledge but surpassed me in wealth and prestige, except for the righteous intentions and kindheartedness they displayed in word and deed. I restrained my soul whenever it incited me to envy such men and to desire a similar social standing. "Soul," I said, "can't you distinguish gain from loss? Will you not stop yearning for something the acquisition of which brings little enjoyment and great trouble and confusion, the loss of which brings great anguish, and the consequences of which after death are grievous?

"Soul, will you give no thought to what comes next, after this place? 3.3
Doesn't that make you forget the things you crave in this world? Will you not abstain from sharing the love that ignorant sinners feel for this fleeting and transient companion, where nothing you possess belongs to you or remains with you, loved only by the deluded and the heedless? Turn from this foolishness and levity, and strive with all your strength, energy, and wherewithal to lay up for yourself future blessings and reward. Beware of procrastination and indifference. Know that this fragile body is prey to infirmities; that it is filled with impure, corruptible mixtures bound together by four mutually antagonistic humors, all sustained by life; and that life will end. The body is like an idol made up of separate parts held together by a single nail: if the nail is removed, the parts will collapse.

"Soul, don't be beguiled by the companionship of friends and loved ones, 3.4
and don't yearn for it too strongly; though their companionship brings joy and happiness, it also brings much suffering and pain, and ultimately ends in parting. It is like a wooden ladle, which can be used in a heated pot for as long as it lasts, but which ends up being tossed into the fire as soon as it breaks.

"Soul, don't let the desire to please your family and relatives lead you to destroy yourself by acquiring possessions. Don't be like a stick of incense that burns up while others enjoy its fragrance. Don't be beguiled by wealth and rank that lead people to insolence, not seeing the insignificance of the things they prize until they're gone, lest you be like hair on the head: cared for as long as it is there, but discarded as refuse once it is gone. Treat the sick diligently. Don't become discouraged and say that medicine demands great labor or that people are ignorant of its benefits and value. Consider that to relieve one person's distress, and rescue him so that he returns to his former state of comfort and ease, deserves the greatest reward and finest recompense. If doing this for a single person deserves such credit, then what about the physician who, in search of reward, treats ever so many patients—people who, after suffering pains and ailments that prevented them from enjoying the world and its pleasures—food, drink, spouses, and children—become even healthier than they were before? Surely such a physician should harbor great hopes and be certain of a fine reward for his knowledge. 3.5

"Soul, don't think that the everlasting world of the hereafter is far off. Don't be so inclined to the transitory world of the here and now that in your haste to make a paltry profit, exchanging much for little, you become like the merchant, who, they say, had a roomful of peaches and said, 'It'll take too long to sell them by weight!'—so he sold them in bulk for a pittance." 3.6

When I had disputed with my soul, cautioned it, and gotten it to see this, it could find no escape; it conceded, agreed, and turned away from its former desires. I made it my practice to treat the sick for the sake of a reward in the hereafter. This did not, however, prevent me from amassing a sizable fortune, even more than I deserved, from kings, friends, and colleagues, both before I went to India and after my return. 3.7

But when I thought about medicine, I realized that no physician could treat a patient with a drug that eliminated the disease so thoroughly that it, or a similar disease, or an even more serious one, would never recur. I didn't see how I could regard something as a cure, when there was no guarantee the same disease wouldn't recur or a worse one develop. On the other hand, I found that work focused on the hereafter offered a deliverance such that a 3.8

person would obtain a cure that removed his fear of all diseases. My esteem for medicine accordingly diminished and I turned to religion.

3.9 When this occurred to me, I was unclear about the subject of religion. In no medical books did I find any discussion that could lead me to the religion that was truest and offered the best guidance. Religious communities were many and diverse, and their adherents fell into three groups: those who inherited their religion from their forefathers, those who had been forced by fear to adopt their religion, and those who sought worldly pleasures, status, and prosperity through their religion. Each group claimed that their religion provided true guidance and that all who thought otherwise were in error. They differed greatly about the Creator and creation, the beginning and the end of things, and other matters. Each rejected the other and denounced its adherents as enemies. I therefore decided to examine the doctrines espoused by every religious community and its leaders, and look into what they prescribed and what they prohibited. In this way, I hoped to distinguish truth from falsehood, and then choose the truth and cling to it with confidence and certainty, rather than believing in something I didn't know or accepting something I couldn't understand. I did this and conducted inquiries, but I found that no one went beyond praising his own religion and disparaging the religion of those who disagreed with him. It became clear to me that their responses and arguments were arbitrary and tendentious. In none of them did I find any mark of impartiality and truth that could be recognized and accepted by a reasonable person.

3.10 *The Credulous Burglar*

This being so, I realized that it was impossible for me to follow any of them. I saw that if I agreed with any of them on something about which I had no knowledge, I would be like the credulous dupe who went to commit a burglary. He and his companions climbed onto the roof of a rich man's house at night. The householder heard their footsteps, woke up, and sensed their presence. Realizing that no honest man would be on the roof at that hour, he roused his wife and whispered to her, "I think thieves have climbed onto our house. I'll pretend to be asleep. You wake me up in a voice loud enough to be heard by someone on the roof, and ask, 'Master of the house, won't you tell me where you got all your riches and treasures?' When I refuse, keep badgering me with questions."

The wife posed the question as instructed, and the thieves listened in. "Woman," said the husband, "destiny has led you to great prosperity, so eat, drink, and hold your tongue! Don't ask me to reveal anything that might be overheard and have unpleasant consequences for you and me both."

But the wife insisted: "Tell me, husband! By God, there's nobody here to hear our conversation!"

And he responded, "If you really want to know, I accumulated this wealth and these treasures by stealing."

"How could that be," she asked, "when everyone thinks you're honest and upstanding—a man no one mistrusts?"

"That," he said, "is because I became so adept at thievery and went about it with such ease and skillfulness that I was above suspicion."

"How so?" she asked.

"I would go out with my friends on a moonlit night," he replied, "climb onto the roof of the house I wanted to rob, and find the skylight through which the moonlight shone into the house. Then I would recite the charm '*Shawlam, shawlam*' seven times, wrap my arms around a moonbeam, and slide down—my landing would escape detection. Next, I would stand at the base of the moonbeam and repeat the charm seven times; any money or valuables in the house would become visible, and I would take whatever I wanted. Then I would grab hold of the moonbeam, repeat the charm seven times, return to my friends, get them to carry all I had seized, and we would slip away."

When the thieves heard this description, they rejoiced: "This is even 3.11
better than the money we were going to get from this house: we now have knowledge whereby God has banished our fears and rendered us safe from the authorities." They waited until they thought the man and his wife had gone back to sleep. Thinking that what they had heard was true, their leader went to the skylight, said, "*Shawlam, shawlam*" seven times, threw his arms around a moonbeam to lower himself into the house, and fell head over heels. The owner of the house jumped on him and gave him a thrashing. "Who are you?" he asked.

"I am a credulous dupe," answered the man, "and this is what comes of believing nonsense."

Wary of believing something that might have perilous consequences, I went back to investigating the various religions, seeking to justify adherence to any one of them. But from no one I questioned did I receive any answers that my reason found worthy of belief or adherence. So I said to myself, "If I can find no one I can trust, the sensible thing is to adhere to the religion of my fathers." But try as I might, I could find no justification for doing so. By this reasoning, I realized, the sorcerer who discovers his father is a sorcerer is justified in following his example—clearly a specious argument. I was reminded of the glutton who, when rebuked, excused himself by saying that his father and grandfather were gluttons. **3.12**

Finding it impossible to adhere to the religion of my fathers or to justify doing so, I wanted to devote more time to religious investigations and inquiries, but it occurred to me how near my end might be and how swiftly earthly life ceases. For all I knew, my departure from the world might come faster than the flick of a wrist. I planned to perform what I hoped were good deeds, but perhaps my hesitation, my querying, and my prospecting would keep me from performing those very deeds, and perhaps my time might come before I found what I was seeking. Through my indecision and vacillation, I might suffer the fate of the man who, they say, fell in love with a married woman. She dug him a tunnel from her house to the street and put the key by the water jar, for fear they might be surprised by her husband. One day, while she and her lover were together, word came that her husband was at the door, so she said to the man, "Hurry and leave through the tunnel by the water jar!" **3.13**

The Perplexed Lover

The man rushed to the place, but found that the jar had been moved. So he came back to the woman and said, "I got to the tunnel, but the jar you mentioned isn't there."

"Fool!" said the woman. "Why are you worrying about the jar? I only mentioned it to help you find the way to the tunnel."

"Since there's no jar by the tunnel," he replied, "you shouldn't have mentioned it and gotten me so confused."

"Good grief!" she cried. "Save yourself! Enough of this foolishness and hesitation."

"But how can I leave," he said, "when you've gotten me so confused?"

So he carried on until the master of the house arrived, gave the wretch a thrashing, and handed him over to the authorities.

3.14 Anxious about indecision and vacillation, I decided not to expose myself to the risk I feared. I decided to limit myself to deeds universally regarded as righteous and on which all religions concur. I avoided murder, assault, extortion, theft, and treachery. I kept myself chaste with respect to women. I guarded my tongue from lies and hurtful speech. I refrained from insult, obscenity, falsehood, slander, and ridicule. I strove never to wish anyone ill. I would not deny belief in the resurrection and reckoning, the reward and punishment. I avoided evildoers and associated with righteous and virtuous people. I saw that no friend or companion compares to knowledge, and that—with God's help and assistance—acquiring it is easy. I discovered that it has more affection for and devotion to those who possess it than his own parents. I came to see that dispensing it does not diminish it, but that instead it increases when dispensed. I found that, in spite of constant use and wear, it is always replenished. And I saw that one needn't fear that it will be confiscated by rulers, or damaged by disasters, floods, fire, invasions, thieves, or vermin.

3.15 *The Merchant and the Musician*

The man who shuns righteousness and its reward and is distracted from it by a taste of the world's sweetness has spent his days, I realized, like the merchant in the following story. Once, they say, a merchant who possessed many valuable jewels hired a man for a hundred dinars a day to bore holes in the jewels and prepare them.[13] He brought the man to his house. When the man sat down, he saw a harp lying in a corner of the room. "Can you play the harp?" the merchant asked.

"Yes," replied the man.

"Go ahead!" said the merchant.

So the man picked it up and skillfully played one beautiful, plaintive air after another until the evening. The merchant forgot all about his jewels and was completely absorbed by the music.

When evening came, the man said to the merchant, "Pay me my day's wages."

And the merchant replied, "Have you done anything to be paid for?"

"Yes," said the man, "I did what you ordered me to do."

So the merchant paid him a hundred dinars, and his jewels remained unworked.

3.16 The more I considered the world and its desires, the more I was moved to renounce them. I resolved to cling to acts of devotion and asceticism. I realized that asceticism smooths the path to one's ultimate state just as parents smooth the path for their child. I recognized it as a shield sure to ward off persistent evil, and as the gate that opens to the garden of bliss. I found that the ascetic, after meditating, is enveloped in tranquility; in his calmness, he becomes humble; in his contentment, he is free of want; in his satisfaction, he experiences no anxiety. He has cast off the world, and has escaped from its evils; he has rejected cravings, and has become pure; he is spared sorrows, and is safe from regret; he inspires no fear, so men do not fear him; he commits no transgressions, so is in no danger. The longer I considered the ascetic life, the more I was drawn to it, to the point that I was on the verge of living among its devotees.

3.17 Then I grew fearful that I might not be able to endure the life of an ascetic; that I might be hindered by the habits I had been raised and nurtured on. I was afraid that if I renounced the world and embraced asceticism, I might be too weak to sustain it; and that, having renounced the work I had formerly pursued in hope of a good return, I would be like the dog who passed by a river with a bone in his mouth and, seeing its reflection in the water, jumped in to grab it, losing what he had in his mouth and not getting what he coveted. Thus, although I had great respect for the ascetic life, I feared that my soul might become distressed and impatient. So I decided to remain as I was.

3.18 It then occurred to me to weigh the suffering and privation of the ascetic life, which I feared I might be too weak to sustain, against the troubles that assail a man in this world, and it became clear to me that there are no worldly

cravings or pleasures that do not turn into suffering and cause sorrow. The world is like salt water: the more you drink, the thirstier you become. It is like a bone picked up by a dog: he smells meat and gnaws at the bone until his mouth bleeds—the more he gnaws, the more it bleeds. It is like a kite that snatches a scrap of meat: other birds mob and harass her until, exhausted, she flees and drops it. It is like a jar of honey with poison at the bottom: your first taste is sweet, but death lurks below. It is like a dream that brings the sleeper joy but vanishes as soon as he wakes. It is like lightning that flashes for a moment and disappears, leaving in darkness the person who hopes for rain. It is like the silkworm: the more silk it wraps around itself, the more difficult it is for it to find a way out.

3.19 As I pondered these things, I again considered my decision about the ascetic life and striving to attain it. I debated with myself, saying, "It isn't right to flee from the world to asceticism whenever I ponder the world's evils, and from asceticism to the world whenever I consider the hardship asceticism involves—always shifting, without ever making a decision or resolving on a course of action, like the judge of Marw, who listened to the first litigant and ruled against his opponent, then listened to the opponent and ruled against the litigant."

3.20 I reflected on the annoyance and privation that the ascetic endures and said to myself, "How small and insignificant a hardship, compared to the rest and repose of eternity!" And I reflected on the worldly pleasures for which the soul hungers and said to myself, "How bitter and noxious they are, leading as they do toward eternal punishment and humiliation! Why not regard as sweet the brief bitterness that brings lasting sweetness in its wake? Why not regard as bitter the brief sweetness that brings a legacy of lasting bitterness?"

3.21 I thought, if a man were offered a hundred years of being cut to pieces every day, revived, then suffering the same again the next day, with the promise that when the hundred years were over he would escape all suffering and attain peace and happiness, he would be right to consider those years as nothing. How can one refuse to endure a few days of asceticism and a bit

of discomfort, when the world is nothing but suffering, affliction, and torment? Isn't man buffeted by affliction from the moment he's conceived till the end of his days? Medical books tell us that when the fluid destined to become a fully formed infant enters the womb, it mingles with a woman's fluid and blood; it curdles and thickens, and the wind churns the water and blood until they become like the fluid from which cheese is made.[14] Then it thickens like curds, and the infant's organs take shape at the proper time. If it is a girl, it faces its mother's belly; if male, its mother's back. After sixty nights, its formation is complete. It lies constricted within the caul as if bound in a sack, breathing with difficulty, as if every one of its members were in fetters. Above it lie the heat and weight of the stomach, and below it lie darkness and constriction. It is connected by a cord from its navel to its mother's navel, by which it lives and draws on her food and drink. Its hands are on its cheeks, its chin on its legs. It remains in this state of distress, darkness, and constriction until the day it is to be born. When that process begins, the element of wind is given power over the mother's womb and the infant becomes strong enough to move. It turns its head toward the outlet, and because of its narrowness it experiences what a man held in the stocks experiences when they are tightened.

3.22 When the infant arrives on earth and feels the wind or the stroke of a hand, it feels pain like the flaying of skin. From then on, it suffers in all sorts of ways: it hungers, but cannot ask for food; thirsts, but cannot ask for drink; feels pain, but cannot ask for help. Add to this the experience of being picked up and put down, swaddled and unswaddled, anointed and wiped clean. If the infant falls asleep on its back, it cannot turn over—not to mention all sorts of other torments that continue while it is a nursling.

3.23 Having escaped the torment of being a nursling, the child begins the torment of discipline, purges, pains, and sicknesses. When he comes of age, there are worries about money, family, and children, along with fatigue, greed, covetousness, and the risks of buying and selling. In all this, his four enemies—gall, phlegm, blood, and black bile—are in a state of commotion

within him, as well as wind; add to this deadly poisons, venomous snakes, and the fear inspired by men and by wild beasts; and he must also fear heat, cold, rain, and wind. Then come the pains of old age, for those who reach it. Even if he has no fear of these things and is guaranteed safety from them, he has to meditate on the moment of death, when he will bid the world farewell. He should meditate on what will descend on him at that moment: separation from family, loved ones, and kin, and from all that we cling to and desire in the world, and the impending terror to come after death. He would be deemed feeble and negligent if he did not make diligent provision and prepare in advance for its sudden appearance and reject the lusts and beguilements of this world that divert him and distract him from preparing for what he must face.

This is especially true in this decayed age, which resembles nothing so 3.24
much as dregs and mud. We see Time everywhere turn its back, so that it is as if Virtue had bidden its people farewell. Gone are the things whose loss we lament; present are the things whose presence is noxious. It is as if Good were wilting and Evil flourishing; as if Error were advancing in laughter, Integrity retreating in tears; as if Justice had set, Injustice risen; as if Knowledge had been buried, Ignorance resurrected; as if Love had been disinherited, Hatred and Resentment rewarded; as if Obscenity were awake, Shame fast asleep; as if Lying were fresh and fecund, Truth withered and dry; as if Capriciousness and Misrule had been given authority over rulers; as if the Oppressed had been cast deep into the earth, and the Tyrant had raised his head in exaltation; as if Greed, its maw agape in all directions, were devouring everything near and far, and Contentment had become unknown; as if the Ignorant were lifting their heads to the heavens, while the Pious and Good were sinking into the bowels of the earth. Virtue has been hurled from the loftiest height into the lowest abyss, Villainy is revered, and Authority has passed from people of merit to people of mediocrity. It is as if This World were proclaiming in joy and delight, "I have caused Good to disappear and made Evil manifest."

When I considered the world and its affairs and how man, its noblest and most excellent creature, wallows in evil despite his station, so that evil becomes his main characteristic, I realized that anyone with the least intelligence could comprehend this and make provision for his soul, work for its deliverance, and seek its safety, and I was utterly amazed. I pondered and perceived that the only thing standing in the way of achieving this was a paltry bit of pleasure that comes from the senses—smell, taste, hearing, sight, and touch—the chance of obtaining something pleasant or hoping to gain a trifle of indescribable slightness soon to be cut short and wiped away. That is what distracts man from attending to his soul and seeking deliverance. **3.25**

I have tried to find an analogy for this. It is like a man driven by fear to take refuge in a well. He lowers himself into it and clings to two branches on its edge.[15] His feet find something to support them. He looks down, and behold—his feet rest on four snakes that have thrust their heads out of their nests. He looks at the bottom of the well, and behold—a man-eating dragon with its mouth agape. He looks up, and behold—at the base of the branches are two rats, one white, the other black, gnawing away tirelessly. While he ponders his situation and tries to find a way to save himself, he sees some bees nearby that have made a bit of honey; he tastes it, and it distracts him from thinking about his situation and finding a way to escape. He forgets that his feet rest on four snakes—any of which, for all he knows, might attack him at any moment—and that the two rats are busily eating away at the branches, and that when they are cut he will fall into the well. And thus he continues, blissfully heedless, until he perishes. **3.26**

The Man in the Well

I liken the well to the world, filled as it is with plagues, evils, perils, and dangers. I liken the snakes to the four humors, any of which, when excited, is like snake venom and deadly poison. I liken the two branches to life: the black rat to night and the white rat to day. I liken their constant gnawing at the branches to the cycle of night and day that consumes one's allotted time. I liken the dragon to destiny, from which there is no escape. I liken the honey **3.27**

to the scant sweetness a human being receives that distracts him from his soul, making him forget his condition, diverting him from his welfare, and turning him from the path of deliverance.

In the end, I found contentment with my situation and with performing my work to the best of my ability,[16] hoping to find in future days a guide to lead me aright, a ruler over my soul, and aides to help me in my affairs.[17] I remained in this state and returned home from India, having transcribed a number of their books, including this one. 3.28